

Chapter 104-4

The belittling on the spot wasn't the worst part. After the little boy's family left, Yang Jiani asked Qi Jiao: "Why did you play a wrong note?"

Qi Jiao said in a low voice: "I'm sorry."

Her voice was trembling, and her body shivered.

But Yang Jiani said: "I don't accept 'I'm sorry.' Jiaojiao, you know I like watching you play the piano."

"I'm sorry, Mom. I won't do it again. I won't slack off anymore," Qi Jiao said.

But she knew she had already done her best. She had put in 120% effort, yet this was still the best she could do.

She also knew that Yang Jiani didn't like hearing that she had no talent, so she could only say it was because she had been slacking and hadn't done her best yet.

While Yang Jiani was scolding her, Qi Xiangui suddenly slapped Yang Jiani across the face.

Qi Jiao was scared, but she still stubbornly stood in front of Yang Jiani. She didn't dare cry and could only call out "Daddy" to try to make Qi Xiangui stop.

But Qi Xiangui, who had just been drinking with his old classmate, wouldn't listen. He even hit her too. Yang Jiani rushed over and held her tightly, shielding her beneath her body.

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Qi Jiao's childish voice echoed in the darkness. She said to the young Liang Shi: "I'm so sad. Why does my dad hit my mom?"

Liang Shi comforted her: "Jiejie¹, things will be better when we grow up."

Qi Jiao asked her with a smile, revealing a small dimple: "What can we do when we grow up?"

Liang Shi sat shoulder to shoulder with her on the cold ground. The basement was also dim, with no light at all.

"When we grow up, we can go to many places. We'll have money, freedom, and a castle."

They kept imagining light and freedom in the darkness.

Qi Jiao said to her: "Then what do you want to do in the future?"

Liang Shi thought about it. "I want to be a teacher."

"Why?" Qi Jiao asked.

Liang Shi: "I want to give warmth to many children. Even if they don't have a happy family, they can still have a happy school life."

"Then I want to be a teacher too," Qi Jiao said. "Let's be kindergarten teachers, okay?"

Liang Shi extended her finger and made a pinky promise² with her.

In that dark basement, they spent many days huddled together for warmth.

Children have no concept of time passing.

It might have been ten days, or it might have been twenty.

Qi Jiao didn't stay for very long because she still had many classes to attend. But Liang Shi spent most of her time in that basement. Almost every day, Yang Jiani would come and ask her: "Will you be good?"

It was like taming an animal—grinding away all her edges, training her until she didn't dare resist or say anything else.

Liang Shi said: "I'll be good. I'll listen to Mom."

But at that time, she missed her eldest brother, missed Qi Jiao, and even missed that unreliable second brother who would take her out to play wildly but would jump into the water without hesitation to save her when she fell in. So when faced with Yang Jiani's words, "Your mom is the person who treats you best in this world," she couldn't repeat them.

But after staying in that place for so long, the only way to get out was to obey.

After who knows how many days had passed, only after she had repeated "My mom is the person who treats me best in this world" nearly hundreds or thousands of times did she finally leave that dark space.

She had once made promises with Qi Jiao in that dark basement—that they would become kindergarten teachers together in the future, that they would go see the ocean together, that they would become explorers together, that they would build a castle.

Qi Jiao had told her: We both have to grow up well. When we grow up, everything will be better.

They had made pinky promises there. Even in the darkness, when they looked at each other, their eyes were filled with light.

Back then, they could embrace each other for warmth.

But in other dark memories, no one embraced her for warmth.

Still in a dark space, the young her was locked in an airtight box. Qiu Zimin said: "Are you ready? Hide-and-seek starts now."

Her small body curled up inside. After waiting for a long time, she kept asking: "Is it over yet?"

But no one responded, and when she pushed on the box lid, she couldn't open it at all.

She was so scared that she wailed inside the box, but no one paid attention to her.

The young her kept calling for Mama, but no one responded.

She was suffocating inside for a long time, unable to breathe fresh air. She felt like she was going to die.

After who knows how long, she finally woke up in a hospital. What met her eyes was stark white. She looked at Qiu Zimin sitting by the bed and asked: "Mama, why didn't you come find me?"

"I went to hide too and forgot about you," Qiu Zimin said.

Qiu Zimin also liked to lock her in cabinets—still complete darkness.

Qiu Zimin said: "This is a game between just the two of us. You can't tell anyone. Mama loves you the most. If others find out, Mama will be sad, and I'll bring others to play the game too. Then you won't be Mama's favorite child anymore."

The young Liang Shi didn't understand the specifics, but she didn't want others to play this game with her.

Because she herself didn't like playing this either.

But when she suggested playing a different game, Qiu Zimin's expression changed: "What do you want to play? Then should I send you to Auntie Jiani's house again to play with Jiejie Qi Jiao?"

And there were countless times she mentioned that if Liang Shi told anyone about this, Qiu Zimin would send her to Yang Jiani's place.

If she told her eldest brother and second brother about this, Yang Jiani would send them there too.

Naturally, Liang Shi wouldn't say anything.

That dark, airtight basement became a nightmare-like existence for her.

She didn't have claustrophobia, but she would subconsciously feel afraid in darkness.

The dark memories that followed belonged to the original host. Liang Shi saw them from an observer's perspective.

The adolescent original host curled up in that dark room. Her favorite spot was behind the door—she had drunk alcohol behind the door, self-harmed behind the door, cried alone behind the door, and slept behind the door.

And there was that dream where the face had never been shown.

In a dark space, the original host lay on a cold bed wearing sheer clothing as thin as cicada wings³. A clear, cold female voice said: "I like to paint things that are broken."

After saying this, a whip came down.

The whip landed on the original host with the sound of whistling air.

The original host's toes curled from the pain. Cold sweat beaded on her forehead. Her face showed coldness and disgust, which only aroused the other person's interest even more.

"Yes, I like that expression of yours," the female voice said. "You'd better keep it that way."

After saying this, another lash of the whip came down.

The original host closed her eyes briefly. Those eyes were cold and without warmth, carrying a detached weariness of the world.

Someone crouched down. She casually pinned up her hair with a hairclip, but her face couldn't be seen clearly at all.

Only her clear, cold voice remained: "Why are you so obedient yet so rebellious? Heh, I like it."

Her long nails, painted bright red, lightly traced across the original host's chin, then suddenly dug in: "They all say Qiu Zimin dotes on her third daughter the most, but why did she send you to me to be a model for a painting? A-Shi."

The way she called "A-Shi" was tender yet carried an icy feel.

The original host's lips moved slightly: "Get lost."

The other person laughed. The sound grew louder and louder, but when her laughter stopped, another whip came down.

At the same time, someone pushed open the door and called out: "A-Shuang."

Footnotes:

¹ Jiejie (姐姐): Chinese for "older sister." It can be used for actual sisters or as a respectful/affectionate term for older girls or women.

² Pinky promise (拉鉤): A childhood gesture of making a promise by interlocking pinky fingers, common in Chinese culture. It's often accompanied by a rhyme about keeping one's promise.

³ Thin as cicada wings (薄如蟬翼): A Chinese idiom describing something extremely thin and delicate, like the translucent wings of a cicada.